

Studying the Feminist Agency through *The Blazing World*

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ENG 110: Literature for Life

Margaret Cavendish (1622-1673)

- The first author to have crafted the multiverse.
- The fiction was written during the English Civil War (King Charles I was executed in 1649, and England became Republican for several decades, particularly from 1649 to 1660. She met her husband in Paris, who was on the losing side-The Royalist side of the war. She was married to William Cavendish, the Duke of Newcastle)
- She also wrote “Observations Upon Experimental Philosophy” where she mentions

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“Scripture expresses the framing of this world, yet it doth not say, that nature herself was then created; but only that this world was put into such a frame and state, as it is now; and, who knows but there may have been many other worlds before, and of another figure than this is: nay, if nature be infinite, there must also be infinite worlds; for I take, with Epicurus, this world but for a part of the universe; and as there is self-motion in nature, so there are also perpetual changes of particulars, although God himself be immovable; for God acts by his all-powerful decree or command, and not after a natural way” (Cavendish 264)

The Blazing World (1666)

- Divided into three parts
- The introduction and the epilogue
- Divided into three parts
 - (i) The First Part is Romancical;
 - (ii) The Second Philosophical; and
 - (iii) The Third is meerly Fancy; or (as I may call it) Fantastical.



What is the author trying to say?

- Utopian (the “what if”s of society, individualistic decisions etc
- Gender Equality, Feminist Agency
- Critique of Human Society
- Representation of Power dynamic
- Science, Ethics and Technology



Meta?

- Travel to another world
- Multiverse stories: travel narratives
- Another world: rules, laws, histories, customs
- Glimpse of *paths not taken*